energizer for supernovae was—in Oppenheimer's view—a far-out, flaky speculation. Coming from Lev Landau, a neutron core as the energizer for a normal star was worthy of serious thought. Might the Sun actually possess such a core? Oppenheimer vowed to find out.

Oppenheimer's style of research was completely different from any encountered thus far in this book. Whereas Baade and Zwicky worked together as co-equal colleagues whose talents and knowledge complemented each other, and Chandrasekhar and Einstein each worked very much alone, Oppenheimer worked enthusiastically amidst a large entourage of students. Whereas Einstein had suffered when required to teach, Oppenheimer thrived on teaching.

Like Landau, Oppenheimer had gone to the mecca of theoretical physics, Western Europe, to get educated; and like Landau, Oppenheimer, upon returning home, had launched a transfusion of theoretical physics from Europe to his native land.

By the time of his return to America, Oppenheimer had acquired so tremendous a reputation that he received offers of faculty jobs from ten American universities including Harvard and Caltech, and from two in Europe. Among the offers was one from the University of California at Berkeley, which had no theoretical physics at all. "I visited Berkeley," Oppenheimer recalled later, "and I thought I'd like to go there because it was a desert." At Berkeley he could create something entirely his own. However, fearing the consequences of intellectual isolation, Oppenheimer accepted both the Berkeley offer and the Caltech offer. He would spend the autumn and winter in Berkeley, and the spring at Caltech. "1 kept the connection with Caltech.¼ it was a place where 1 would be checked if 1 got too far off base and where 1 would learn of things that might not be adequately reflected in the published literature."

At first Oppenheimer, as a teacher, was too fast, too impatient, too overbearing with his students. He didn't realize how little they knew; he couldn't bring himself down to their level. His first lecture at Caltech in the spring of 1930 was a tour de force—powerful, elegant, insightful. When the lecture was over and the room had emptied, Richard Tolman, the chemist-turned-physicist who by now was a close friend, remained behind to bring him down to earth: "Well, Robert," he said; "that was beautiful but 1 didn't understand a damned word."